

DINO BUZZATI THE SINGULARITY

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nyrb

“FOR MANY years, my dear Ismani,” Endriade said, “ever since I was a young man—even before receiving my degree—I have been obsessed by a question: Does the so-called light of the spirit, in order to form and exist, strictly require man? Is everything external to us dark? Or can this phenomenon, interesting I would say, also be created elsewhere as long as a body, an organism, an instrument, a suitable vessel is found?”

The two of them were alone, in the living room of Endriade’s cottage. A clock on the wall read two thirty in the morning. There was the deep silence of the night, though with that vague hum beneath it, almost like that of a distant waterfall.

“An automaton, you mean?” Ismani asked.

“Hold on. Have you ever considered the strange path of life through the millennia of millennia? At the beginning, who were we? Protozoa, Coelenterata. Sensibility existed, but it was rudimentary. The spirit, what is called the soul, had not yet been born. Or rather it was a flame so tiny, timid, and faltering that differentiating it from the vegetable world was barely demonstrable. Mind you, dear Ismani, I am not speaking in scientific terms here. I’m telling you a kind of parable so you can get a clear idea of the whole business. Do you think I don’t see your curiosity, your discomfiture, your

skepticism? What is the point, you're wondering, of this tremendous effort? It would be madness, worse yet criminal foolishness, to have created this chaos to obtain a travesty of the brain, for a robot capable of computing, of logging and recalling impressions, of laughing, crying, sneezing, or solving problems. What, then? So... Well then, little by little, as millennia went by, evolution, the progress of rational faculties or at any rate conditioned reflexes, or at least sensibility... Do you see? At some point in this interminable journey, voilà, the phenomenon that I call the most mind-blowing enormity ever recorded in the history of creation."

Ismani laughed. "Man?"

"Man." Endriade nodded. "In whom, with positively precipitous speed, within a few million years you could say, a deformation was produced, a case of gigantism, a tumescence that I very nearly doubt was intended in the initial plan of creation, so little does it align with all the rest."

"A deformation?"

"That's right. The cerebral mass becomes increasingly dominant, the skull expands, the nervous system reaches a complexity that is frightening—in short, man's intellect progressively outdistances that of all the other animals. Would you like to talk about the divine breath here, my dear Ismani? Let's talk about it. The phenomenon, considered objectively, does not change."

"But I don't see what relation—"

"Hear me out. One more phase. The matter is absolutely obvious, but I have to tell you everything. So then. Well. Developing abnormally, at some point man's brain, his nervous system, and his overall sensibility... At a certain point, my dear colleague, an imponderable element entered the

scene, an incorporeal extension of the body, an invisible yet sensitive growth, a protuberance that has no precise dimensions, weight, or shape, which we don't know for sure even exists, scientifically speaking. But that poses so many difficulties for us: the soul!"

"And Number One would be—"

"One more moment, be patient. I posit, and this is the fundamental point. I posit: If we build a machine that reproduces our mental activity without the lead weight of being tied to a particular language, a machine that processes and solves problems infinitely faster than a human and with much less probability of error, can we speak of intelligence? No. Intelligence, to exist, needs a minimum of autonomy, freedom. But if instead—"

"If instead we build Number One. Is that what you mean?"

"Yes, exactly! If we were to build . . . oh I'm not saying that we'd succeed . . . but if we built a machine that has perceptions like us, that thinks like us—a question of money by now, a matter of time and effort—why should that scare us? If we can manage to build it, that famous product, that impalpable essence, thought, I mean, the indefatigable flow of ideas that never rests, even in sleep . . . there's more, there's more, not only thought but its individualization, its distinctive character, in short that puff of air that sometimes weighs on us as if it were lead, the soul, the soul would then automatically settle in there. Different from ours? So what? What would it matter if the container, instead of flesh, were made of metal? Isn't stone alive, too?"

Ismani shook his head. "If Monsignor Rizzieri were around to hear us."

"Not likely," Endriade said, smiling. "There is no theological difficulty. Should God maybe be jealous? Doesn't

everything come from him anyway? Materialism? Determinism? It's a completely different problem. No heresies in the eyes of the Church fathers. On the contrary."

"A desecration of nature, they would say. The supreme sin of pride."

"Nature? But it would be its greatest triumph!"

"And afterwards? What benefit would this immense labor bring about?"

"The objective, my dear Ismani, goes beyond that which man has ever attempted. But it is so grand, so marvelous that it's worth expending even our last breath on it. You're thinking: The day this brain will be greater, more powerful, more perfect, more intelligent than ours... that day won't be as great as... how shall I put it? I'm not a philosopher. A superhuman sensibility and rational power will also correspond to a superhuman spirit. And won't that day be the most glorious in history? At that time a spiritual power that the world has never known will emanate from the machine, an irrepressible, beneficial flow. The machine will read our thoughts, create masterpieces, reveal the most hidden mysteries."

"And what if one day the automaton's way of thinking eschewed your commands and acted on its own?"

"It's what we're hoping for. It would mean success. Without freedom, what kind of spirit would it be?"

"And what if, with a soul like ours, it becomes corrupt like us? Could action be taken to correct it? And with its awesome intelligence, wouldn't it be able to deceive us?"

"But it was born pure. Just like Adam. Hence its superiority. It isn't stained with original sin." He fell silent.

Ismani scratched his chin, puzzled. "And your installation, Number One, would be—"

"Exactly. It's the prototype. And we have good reason to believe that . . . that . . ."

"That it thinks like us?"

"I hope so."

"And how does it communicate? In what language?"

"No language. Every language is a trap for the mind. We reproduced the functioning of human thought, starting with the primary elements. The description of the relationship between words and things that are named was replaced by a description expressed in terms of activity. It's Ceccatieff's old ingenious system again. Every mental combination translates into a graph that records its history in full, while allowing us to quickly grasp it. It is the actual footprint of thought, without any reference to this or that language."

"And by what means?"

"Magnetic wire. With a very simple system, visible patterns are obtained from this wire."

"And to interpret them?"

"It's a matter of familiarizing yourself with it. By now I read them faster than print. Of course, this is a hindrance. But then there's sound that helps. In addition to a visible graph, you can derive sound from the magnetic wire. And with extensive experience you can understand it."

"You, Endriade, do you understand it? I imagine it must be like a whistle, or a whine."

"Exactly so. Sometimes I'm able to. It's the sound of thinking itself, a strange, exciting feeling. However, understanding or not understanding depends on a special sensibility."

"But take me, for example, given that I'm an outsider, how could this Number One communicate with me?"

"Well now, that's one of your assignments, my dear Ismani. You have to make a kind of dictionary of the mental opera-

tions. Find, insofar as possible, the corresponding word for each combination of signs."

"And you, Endriade, how are you able to communicate with the machine? Does it understand our language?"

"Orders and messages are communicated by means of punch cards. But this is not to rule out that she, the machine, may understand our speech, at least in part."

"It would be monstrous."

"I hear you, dear Ismani. You don't believe it. And in a way, you have every reason not to. But you'll see, you'll see. We've already come a long way. And we'll get there, by now I'm confident. The worst is behind us. The road ahead is the easiest. Yes. We'll create a superman. Even better: for the Demiurge, a kind of god. This, this is the way for us to finally redeem ourselves from misery and loneliness."

"It's frightening. At some point it will be materially impossible to control everything that happens in such a mind."

"Precisely. It's what already happens with our Number One. But there's no need to worry. The conditions, created by us, are sound. We can sleep peacefully."

"And it?"

"What about it?"

"Does it sleep at night? Doesn't it ever rest?"

"Actually sleep, I would say no. Rather, it dozes. At night all of its activity is reduced."

"Do you decrease the energy supply?"

"No, no, it quiets down on its own, just as if it were tired."

"And does it also dream?"